

Most and almost

Teaching guide

Distinguish a majority from something nearly true.

Understand the distinction

Most before a plural or uncountable noun means the majority or greatest part: most students, most water. Use most of before a determiner or pronoun: most of the students; most of them.

Almost means nearly: almost ready, almost all, almost everyone. It does not normally directly modify a plural noun to mean the majority: say most people or almost all people, depending on your meaning. Almost all is stronger than most.

Compare the patterns

MAJORITY

Most students came.

More than half came; the precise number is unstated.

NEARLY EVERYONE

Almost all the students came.

Very few were absent.

NEARLY A STATE

The room is almost ready.

Some preparation remains.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: Almost people arrived on time.

- A. Most people arrived on time.
- B. Most people almos~~t~~s arrived on time.
- C. Almost of the people arrived on time.

2. Complete: Most ___ them agreed.

- A. to
- B. from
- C. of

3. Which suggests a larger share: most / almost all?

- A. Neither; both mean exactly half.
- B. most
- C. almost all

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly describes a majority of classmates and a nearly finished project?

- A. Most of my classmates walk to school. Our project is almost finished.
- B. Almost my classmates walk to school. Our project is almost finished.
- C. Most of my classmates walk to school. Our project is most finished.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. Most people arrived on time.

If nearly everyone arrived on time, use Almost all the people instead.

B: Almost does not take an -s ending, and the intended claim is about most people.

C: Use most of the people or almost all of the people, not almost of.

2. C. of

Use of before a pronoun such as them.

A: Use of between most and an object pronoun such as them.

B: Most of them identifies a proportion of that group.

3. C. almost all

It means nearly the entire group.

A: Most means more than half and almost all means nearly everyone or everything.

B: Most means a majority; almost all normally suggests close to the whole group.

4. A. Most of my classmates walk to school. Our project is almost finished.

Most of refers to a proportion of the group; almost means nearly.

B: Use most of my classmates or almost all of my classmates.

C: Use almost finished to mean nearly complete.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-37.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair correctly describes a majority of classmates and a nearly finished project?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.